

NARRATIVE PREACHING

Preaching the Story Without Losing the Text

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1. Why Stories Preach

Much of Scripture comes to us as story. Creation, Abraham, Joseph, Moses, Ruth, David, Elijah, Esther, the Gospels, and Acts do not merely state truths; they show people acting within God's unfolding work. Narrative preaching takes seriously the form in which God chose to give these texts.

A narrative sermon is not simply a sermon containing an illustration. It seeks to let the movement, tension, characters, setting, dialogue, and resolution of a biblical narrative help shape the sermon. The preacher still explains and applies Scripture, but does not flatten a story into three abstract propositions before the congregation has heard it as story.

The controlling principle is simple: the preacher serves the biblical narrative. Imagination may help listeners see the scene, but imagination must never become counterfeit revelation.

2. Narrative Is Not Fiction

Biblical narrative uses literary artistry, but literary artistry does not imply fiction. Repetition, characterization, selective detail, dialogue, pacing, and suspense are ways writers communicate meaning.

The preacher should therefore ask both historical and literary questions. What happened? Where does this episode stand in redemptive history? How has the narrator arranged the account? What details are emphasized or omitted? What changes from beginning to end?

Responsible narrative preaching neither treats the text as a bare chronicle nor turns it into a novel. It respects the claim of the text while attending to the way the story is told.

3. Finding the Story's Boundaries

Before preaching a narrative, determine where the preaching unit begins and ends. Chapter divisions are helpful but are not inspired boundaries. A scene may begin late in one chapter and conclude early in the next.

Look for changes in place, time, characters, action, repeated phrases, and narrative resolution. A useful preaching unit normally contains enough movement to make a coherent episode.

Taking too small a slice can remove the tension or resolution; taking too much can produce a sermon that races through scenes without allowing any of them to work.

4. Setting: Where and When Matter

Setting is more than scenery. A wilderness, palace, prison, battlefield, synagogue, storm, well, road, or tomb can shape the action and the hearer's expectations.

Historical background can clarify setting, but the preacher should distinguish established information from speculation. A dramatic cultural claim repeated online does not become true because it improves a sermon.

Use setting to illuminate what the text gives us. Do not bury the congregation under archaeology when one clear fact is enough.

5. Characters Without Caricature

Narratives reveal characters through speech, action, contrast, response, and sometimes explicit evaluation. Preachers should resist turning every character into either a spotless hero or a cartoon villain.

David can act faithfully in one scene and sin grievously in another. Peter can confess Christ and misunderstand him. Biblical realism allows complex people to remain complex.

Do not invent motives the narrator does not supply. A priest and Levite passing a wounded man may provoke questions, but Luke does not tell us what each man privately thought. The sermon should not present a guess as biblical fact.

6. Plot, Tension, and Movement

Stories move because something changes. A problem appears, tension rises, choices are made, reversals occur, and some form of resolution arrives. Finding that movement helps the preacher discover the sermon's natural structure.

In 1 Samuel 17, the story does not begin with five spiritual principles represented by stones. It moves from Israel's fear and Goliath's challenge through David's confidence in the Lord to deliverance and changed circumstances.

Let the congregation feel the problem before announcing the resolution. Premature explanation can destroy narrative tension.

7. Dialogue: Let the Text Speak

Biblical narratives often place theology in dialogue. Questions, confessions, accusations, promises, misunderstandings, and commands reveal what is at stake.

Notice repeated words and contrasting speeches. Who speaks most? Who is silent? Which words are later fulfilled, corrected, or reversed?

Reading a short exchange aloud can sometimes communicate more than paraphrasing it. The preacher's task is not to improve biblical dialogue but to help the congregation hear its force.

8. Point of View and the Narrator

The narrator controls what the reader knows. Sometimes the reader knows more than a character; sometimes information is withheld. Irony often arises from this difference.

Explicit narrator comments deserve special attention because they guide evaluation. When Scripture tells us that an action was evil in the Lord's sight, the preacher need not invent a moral standard.

Point of view also guards against identifying the sermon automatically with the most attractive character. The theological center may lie in what God is doing rather than in the human protagonist.

9. Repetition, Contrast, and Reversal

Repetition is one of narrative's strongest signals. Repeated phrases, actions, locations, or questions can reveal structure and emphasis. Contrast places characters, responses, or outcomes beside each other.

Reversal is especially powerful: the weak are raised, the proud fall, the outsider responds faithfully, the expected hero fails, the condemned one is vindicated. Scripture repeatedly uses reversal to expose false assumptions.

Good narrative preaching notices these features rather than importing an outline from outside the story.

10. Theological Meaning Without Moralizing

A narrative sermon must do more than tell hearers to imitate the good character and avoid the bad one. Biblical stories participate in the larger story of God's covenant, kingdom, judgment, grace, redemption, and mission.

David and Goliath certainly displays courage, but the text's repeated concern with the name and honor of the Lord prevents the sermon from becoming merely 'face your giants.' Ruth displays loyalty, but the book also concerns providence, redemption, covenant faithfulness, and the preservation of the line that leads to David.

Application grows stronger when it arises from the story's theology rather than from detached character lessons.

11. Preaching Christ from Narrative

Christian preaching reads each narrative within the whole canon and the redemptive work fulfilled in Christ. This does not authorize finding a hidden symbol of Jesus in every object.

Responsible Christ-centered preaching asks where the text stands in the biblical story: creation, fall, promise, covenant, kingdom, exile, return, Messiah, church, new creation. It then shows legitimate canonical connections.

Typology requires textual and canonical warrant. Allegory invented by the preacher may sound spiritual while severing the sermon from what the biblical author actually communicated.

12. Imagination Under Authority

Narrative preaching requires imagination because listeners form mental pictures. The question is not whether imagination will operate but whether it will remain disciplined.

A preacher may say, 'Imagine the silence as David walks toward Goliath,' clearly signaling a rhetorical invitation. The preacher should not say, 'David's hands trembled as he remembered his mother's last words,' when Scripture gives no such information.

Use sensory language where the text or secure background supports it. Mark conjecture honestly. Never place invented words in God's mouth.

13. First-Person Narrative Sermons

A first-person sermon tells the biblical story through the voice of a character. It can create immediacy and help hearers experience the sequence of events.

It also carries unusual risk. The preacher must invent connecting language, and listeners may not know where Scripture ends and imagination begins. Preparation therefore requires especially careful exegesis.

Choose a character whose perspective can carry the story, avoid claiming private thoughts as fact, and consider a brief framing statement that makes the sermon's imaginative method clear.

14. Third-Person and Mixed Forms

Third-person narrative preaching allows the preacher to tell, explain, pause, interpret, and apply without pretending to be a biblical character. It is often the safest and most flexible narrative form.

A mixed sermon may narrate a scene, pause for explanation, return to the story, and then move toward application. The transitions should be deliberate so listeners know whether they are hearing the biblical account, historical background, interpretation, or contemporary application.

Form should serve the text. The preacher does not owe every narrative passage a dramatic monologue.

15. Narrative Introductions and Conclusions

A narrative sermon can begin inside the action: a storm rises, a messenger arrives, a son leaves home, a giant speaks. It can also begin with a contemporary situation that raises the same human question as the text.

Do not spend so long creating atmosphere that the sermon delays Scripture. The introduction should open the story's door, not build a second house in front of it.

The conclusion should resolve the sermon's theological movement. It may return to an image, question, or repeated phrase, but should move hearers toward faith, repentance, hope, obedience, worship, or mission rather than merely ending the plot.

16. Application in Narrative Preaching

Application can occur throughout a narrative sermon, but it should not constantly interrupt the story. Sometimes listeners need to remain inside the scene long enough for its force to accumulate.

Ask where the congregation stands in relation to the truth of the narrative. What should they believe about God? What false assumption is exposed? What response is commanded or invited? What hope is offered? What pattern should be followed or rejected?

Application should cross the bridge from the ancient world to the present without pretending that every circumstance is identical.

17. Preaching Difficult Narratives

Scripture contains violence, sexual sin, abuse, war, judgment, betrayal, and morally disturbing behavior. Do not sanitize these stories, sensationalize them, or assume that everything recorded is approved.

Distinguish description from prescription. Attend to narrator evaluation, canonical teaching, historical setting, and vulnerable hearers in the congregation.

Some texts require explicit pastoral care in presentation. A sermon can tell the truth about rape, domestic violence, suicide, or child loss without exploiting suffering for dramatic effect.

18. From Exegesis to Sermon

Begin by reading the narrative repeatedly in several reliable translations. Mark scenes, characters, setting, dialogue, repetition, conflict, reversals, narrator comments, and resolution. State the main theological claim in one clear sentence.

Then decide what sermon form best serves the text. Build movements from the narrative itself. Select only background that clarifies. Decide where explanation is necessary, where the text can simply be heard, and where application belongs.

Finally read the sermon aloud. Narrative depends on pace, pause, voice, and clarity. Remove invented detail that has begun to sound factual, theological commentary that stops the story unnecessarily, and illustrations that compete with the biblical narrative.

19. A Worked Example: The Good Samaritan

Luke 10:25–37 begins with a lawyer testing Jesus: 'What must I do to inherit eternal life?' Jesus directs him to the law, and the lawyer correctly names love for God and neighbor. Wanting to justify himself, he asks, 'And who is my neighbor?'

Jesus tells of a wounded man, a priest and Levite who pass by, and a Samaritan who sees, has compassion, treats the wounds, transports the man, pays for care, and promises further responsibility. The text does not tell us why the priest and Levite passed by, so the preacher should not preach a guessed motive as fact.

The lawyer asks for a definition that might establish the boundary of obligation. Jesus ends by asking which character became a neighbor to the wounded man. The movement is from defining the neighbor to becoming one. 'Go and do likewise' calls for merciful action; it should not be turned into a claim that mercy earns eternal life.

20. A Worked Example: David and Goliath

First Samuel 17 develops tension through Goliath's repeated challenge and Israel's fear. David hears the same words but interprets the situation differently because he sees the challenge as defiance of the living God.

The sermon should resist both extremes: reducing the story to a children's lesson about bravery and turning every detail into allegory. The stones are stones, not five secret spiritual weapons.

The narrative emphasizes God's honor and God's deliverance. David acts courageously, but his confidence is explicit: the battle belongs to the Lord. Application can address faithful courage precisely because it first understands the theological ground of that courage.

Conclusion: Tell the Story Faithfully

Narrative preaching does not ask the preacher to become an entertainer. It asks the preacher to respect what biblical narrative already does: reveal truth through people, action, speech, tension, reversal, and resolution.

The preacher's imagination is a servant, never a second source of revelation. Exegesis establishes the boundaries; theology identifies the significance; pastoral wisdom carries the story into the lives of hearers.

Tell the story well. Tell the truth about the story. And allow the story to lead the congregation to the God whose acts give Scripture its great and final story.